Excel Formula Cheat Sheet

The Big 5 + data cleaning, dates, and troubleshooting. Keep this by your desk.

⚡ The Big 5 (Must-Know Formulas)

VLOOKUP — Look up a value and return another column

```
=VLOOKUP(lookup_value, table_array, col_index_num, [range_lookup])
```

Lookup_value = what you're searching for · **Table_array** = where to search · **Col_index_num** = which column to return (1 = first column). Use `FALSE` for exact match.

IF — Condition: do one thing or another

```
=IF(condition, value_if_true, value_if_false)
```

Example: `=IF(A1>60,"Pass","Fail")`. Nest IFs for multiple conditions, or use IFS in newer Excel.

SUMIF — Sum only cells that meet a condition

```
=SUMIF(range, criteria, [sum_range])
```

Example: sum sales where region = "North". **Range** = cells to check · **Criteria** = condition · **Sum_range** = cells to sum (optional if same as range).

INDEX + MATCH — Flexible lookup (better than VLOOKUP when columns move)

```
=INDEX(return_range, MATCH(lookup_value, lookup_range, 0))
```

MATCH finds the row (or column) number; INDEX returns the value at that position. Use `0` in MATCH for exact match.

XLOOKUP — Modern replacement for VLOOKUP (Excel 365 / 2021+)

```
=XLOOKUP(lookup_value, lookup_array, return_array, [if_not_found])
```

No column index needed; can search left-to-right. Use `if_not_found` to avoid #N/A (e.g. `"Not found"`).

🧹 Data Cleaning Kit

TRIM — Remove leading/trailing spaces

```
=TRIM(text)
```

Fixes pasted data with extra spaces. Use on the column first, then copy result as values.

Remove duplicates / Unique list

```
=UNIQUE(range)
```

Excel 365: returns unique values. Older Excel: Data → Remove Duplicates, or use advanced filter for unique list.

TEXTSPLIT — Split text by delimiter (Excel 365)

```
=TEXTSPLIT(text, delimiter)
```

Splits "A,B,C" by comma into separate cells. Alternative: Data → Text to Columns.

PROPER / UPPER — Fix capitalization

```
=PROPER(text)
```

```
=UPPER(text)
```

PROPER = first letter of each word uppercase. UPPER = all caps. LOWER = all lowercase.

📅 Date & Time

DATEDIF — Days/months/years between two dates

```
=DATEDIF(start_date, end_date, "Y")
```

Unit: "Y" years, "M" months, "D" days. Great for tenure, contract length. (DATEDIF is undocumented but supported.)

NETWORKDAYS — Working days between dates

```
=NETWORKDAYS(start_date, end_date, [holidays])
```

Excludes weekends. Optional: range of holiday dates. Use for project timelines, SLA days.

EOMONTH — Last day of a month

```
=EOMONTH(start_date, months)
```

Months = 0 for same month, 1 for next month. Use for month-end reporting, due dates.

⚠️ Error Troubleshooting

Error	Common cause	Fix in one line
#N/A	VLOOKUP/MATCH/XLOOKUP didn't find a match	Check lookup value exists, no extra spaces; use IFNA(XLOOKUP(...),"Not found") to hide.
#VALUE!	Wrong type (e.g. text where number expected)	Use VALUE() to convert text to number; check for hidden characters or merged cells.
#REF!	Reference to deleted or moved cells	Re-point formula to correct range or undo delete.
#DIV/0!	Division by zero	Wrap in IF(denominator=0,"",formula) or IFERROR(formula,"").

🚀 Top 10 Shortcuts

Action	Windows	Mac
Copy	Ctrl+C	Cmd+C
Paste	Ctrl+V	Cmd+V
Go to first cell	Ctrl+Home	Ctrl+Fn+Left / Cmd+Home
Go to last used cell	Ctrl+End	Ctrl+Fn+Right / Cmd+End
Edit cell	F2	F2 or Control+U
Fill down	Ctrl+D	Cmd+D
Fill right	Ctrl+R	Cmd+R
New line in cell	Alt+Enter	Control+Option+Enter
Absolute reference (toggle $)	F4	Fn+F4 or Cmd+T
Insert table	Ctrl+T	Cmd+T

Bonus: More on SheetMaster

Get ready-to-use formula generators and templates: **getsheetmaster.com** — Finance, HR, and inventory solutions.